electoral gains. I then told them that the main purpose of my calling them to my room was to tell them, and through them the rest of the Sikh staff members, that what had happened should have no impact on the performance of their duties in the Department.

Our primary responsibility was towards the nation and the protection of its security interests. Religious affiliation was secondary. Reminding them briefly of the sacrifices made by a large number of Sikhs during India's Independence struggle, I finally told them that within the next half hour they should contact all Sikh staff members working in the Department and inform them of my message, which they did. The rest of the day was spent in routine office work, which naturally proceeded at a comparatively slower pace.

'Duty to kill'

In the evening, accompanied by my wife Iqbal, young son Gagan and daughter Harmeeta, I visited Gurudwara Bangla Sahib to see if there was any impact of Operation Blue Star on the Sikhs there. While the Shabad Kirtan (recitation of sacred hymns) was going on inside the main hall, small groups of Sikhs were standing outside here and there, animatedly discussing the outcome of Operation Blue Star. A number of placards in Punjabi with inscriptions in red ink were also displayed prominently.

Both the contents of the placards and the animated discussions were highly critical of the government and especially the Congress, which was being held directly responsible for what had happened at the Golden Temple complex. I still remember the contents of one of the placards displayed near the langar entrance of the gurudwara. It read, '*Singh sahib, Bhai Amrik Singh ate Thara Singh nu tasehe de ke marya gaya hai. Hun is k ... Brahmani nu maran da har Sikh da farz banada hai.'* (Sikh brethren, be informed that brothers Amrik Singh and Thara Singh were tortured to death. Now it becomes the duty of every Sikh to kill this Brahmani).

The word 'Brahmani' was used for Indira Gandhi with a derogatory prefix. Incidentally, there was no placard that mentioned the death of Bhindranwale, as some Sikhs still believed that